now high commissioner of Mesopotamia), had come to concur with Norman and the Indian government. In his opinion, the agreement ‘has become such a red herring to the Bolshevik[s] and such a pretext for extremist propaganda, that I agree with the Government of India that we must drop it in its present form as a basis of policy’.[14] Curzon’s minute that Cox was closer to the mark than anybody else when it came to Persia shows that the Indian government’s ideas were always more palatable to the foreign secretary when they were proposed by anyone other than the viceroy![15]

Unfortunately for Norman, Curzon appeared just as willing to ignore him as the viceroy. Cox had been Curzon’s man and his recommendations on British Persian policy had been exactly what the foreign secretary had wanted to hear. Norman, however, had a different perspective to his predecessor. While he had served in Egypt and Turkey, he had also held positions in the US, Latin America and Europe. Before his appointment to Persia he had been part of the British Delegation to the Paris Peace Conference. Norman had therefore ‘seen a wider changing world and witnessed the rising tide of nationalism’, whereas Cox had spent much of his career ‘dealing with hereditary sheikhs and tribal leaders’.[16] Norman also had no personal attachment to the 1919 agreement and was therefore perhaps more objective. Unfortunately, although he was a man of ‘intelligence and vision’, Norman’s views of the Persian situation were not what Curzon wanted to hear. Try as he might, the diplomat was unable to make the foreign secretary listen to him. Indeed, the relationship between the two became so bad that when Norman finally left Tehran in October 1921, Curzon refused to see him when he arrived in London (as was the general courtesy when a diplomat returned from abroad).[17]

Despite the pleas of Norman to abrogate the agreement, nevertheless, Curzon remained unmoved. As one historian puts it: ‘This stubborn clinging to an obviously imperialistic treaty could only make the worst impression on nationalistically minded Iranians.’[18] The situation became even more farcical when the new Persian prime minister, Seyyed Zia’eddin, took it upon himself to denounce the agreement.[19] On 26 February 1921 in a declaration to the Persian public, Zia’eddin explained: